

Emergence of Pen Testing in Cyber Security

A penetration test is basically a simulated cyber attack against the system in order to check it for vulnerabilities. It is also called 'ethical hacking' or 'white cat hacking'. Pen tests are essential to assess the current security of an IT system. They provide valuable information about security risks and vulnerabilities, and their potential impact on the system's functioning and performance.



Image source: <https://indiancyberinstitute.com>

The cyber threat landscape is changing on a daily basis. Even as one threat is discovered, many unknown ones are waiting in the wings. However, business and corporations can today defend themselves through pen testing. A pen test includes a set of procedures used to discover any unknown weaknesses in the network infrastructure of a business.

Pen testing was first thought of in the 1960s. In 1971, the US Air

Force ordered security testing of its time shared computer systems. As hacking became more advanced, so did penetration testing.

After the WannaCry ransomware attack in May 2017, the concept of pen testing slowly started catching the attention of cyber security personnel. That attack locked more than 200,000 computers around the world, and demanded ransom payments through Bitcoin cryptocurrency. It affected many big organisations across the globe.

Why pen testing?

Pen testing can prove critical in the prevention of cyber attacks. Over 69 per cent of the organisations based in the US do not think their anti-virus protection or firewalls can effectively protect them from cyber attacks. And in 2017, a cyber attack was recorded every 40 seconds in the world, which resulted in total losses of US\$ 5 billion, an astonishing increase from the US\$ 325 million loss in 2015.

